Catherine Vance

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Operations executive with 20 years in industrial manufacturing, the last seven running multi-plant operations of up to 1,400 people. I turn around underperforming plants, build leadership teams that stay, and connect the shop floor to the numbers the board cares about. Most recently led a $40 million modernization that raised on-time delivery from 81% to 96%.

CORE SKILLS

- Operations: Multi-plant leadership, lean manufacturing, plant turnarounds
- Finance: P&L ownership to $310 million, capital planning, cost reduction
- People: Building leadership teams, union relations, safety culture
- Growth: New product launches, capacity expansion, acquisition integration

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Harrowfield Pump Company Charlotte, NC
Vice President of Operations Jan 2019 – Present

- Lead three plants and two distribution centers with 1,400 employees and a $310 million operating budget, reporting to the CEO
- Planned and delivered a $40 million modernization across all three plants on schedule and $2.3 million under budget
- Raised on-time delivery from 81% to 96% and cut warranty claims by 38% over four years
- Brought the recordable injury rate from 4.1 to 1.6 by putting safety walks and near-miss reporting at the center of every plant meeting
- Rebuilt the plant leadership team, and every manager hired since 2020 has stayed
- Integrated an acquired valve business into our operating system in nine months, keeping every major customer and all of its 120 employees

Ironbriar Equipment Works Greenville, SC
Plant Director Mar 2014 – Dec 2018

- Ran a 600-person plant making hydraulic components for construction equipment, with annual output of about $140 million
- Turned the plant from a $6 million loss to a $9 million profit in three years through lean projects, a new shift pattern and better scrap control
- Negotiated two labor agreements with no strikes and half the grievances
- Opened a second assembly line for a new product in 11 months, ahead of plan
- Introduced tiered daily meetings from the shop floor to the plant staff, so problems reached the right level within a day

Brassfork Tooling Dayton, OH
Operations Manager Jun 2010 – Feb 2014

- Managed production, maintenance and quality for a 220-person tooling plant
- Introduced daily production boards and a weekly cost review that cut overtime by 30%
- Led the plant's first ISO 9001 certification, passed with no major findings
- Moved maintenance to a planned schedule and cut unplanned downtime by 25%
- Hired and trained the plant's first team of production supervisors drawn from the shop floor
- Set up a cross-trained maintenance crew that covered all three shifts

- Cut scrap from 4.8% to 2.1% of material cost with operator-led problem solving
- Ran the plant's capital budget of about $3 million a year
- Worked with sales on quoting rules that ended money-losing rush orders

Harmon & Pike Manufacturing Dayton, OH
Industrial Engineer Jul 2006 – May 2010

- Redesigned two assembly cells, raising output per labor hour by 22%
- Built the plant's standard cost model, still in use when I left
- Ran time studies and line balancing for a new product launch with the engineering team

EDUCATION

Larkbriar University Raleigh, NC
Master of Business Administration *May 2013*

Cardinal Ridge University Columbus, OH
Bachelor of Science in Industrial Engineering *May 2006*

BOARD AND AFFILIATIONS

- Board member, Carolinas Manufacturing Roundtable, since 2021
- Advisory board, Larkbriar University Center for Operations Excellence, since 2019